For example, what's the difference between the AI policies of Republicans and Democrats? What's a right-wing position on AI, and what's a left-wing position? Are conservatives against AI because of the threat it poses to traditional human-centred culture, or do they favour it because it will fuel economic growth while simultaneously reducing the need for immigrant workers? Do progressives oppose AI because of the risks of disinformation and increasing bias, or do they embrace it as a means of generating abundance that could finance a comprehensive welfare state? It is hard to tell, because until very recently Republicans and Democrats, and most other political parties around the world, hadn't thought or talked much about these issues.

Some people – like the engineers and executives of high-tech corporations – are way ahead of politicians and voters and are better informed than most of us about the development of AI, cryptocurrencies, social credits and the like. Unfortunately, most of them don't use their knowledge to help regulate the explosive potential of the new technologies. Instead, they use it to make billions of dollars – or to accumulate petabits of information.

There are exceptions, like Audrey Tang. She was a leading hacker and software engineer who in 2014 joined the Sunflower Student Movement, which protested against government policies in Taiwan. The Taiwanese cabinet was so impressed by her skills that Tang was eventually invited to join the government as its minister of digital affairs. In that position, she helped make the government's work more transparent to citizens. She was also credited with using digital tools to help Taiwan successfully contain the COVID-19 outbreak.[51]

Yet Tang's political commitment and career path are not the norm. For every computer-science graduate who wants to be the next Audrey Tang, there are probably many more who want to be the next Jobs, Zuckerberg or Musk and build a multibillion-dollar corporation rather than become an elected public servant. This leads to a dangerous information asymmetry. The people who lead the information revolution know far more about the underlying technology than the people who are supposed to regulate it. Under such conditions, what's the meaning of chanting that the customer is always right and that the voters know best?

The following chapters try to level the playing field a bit and encourage us to take responsibility for the new realities created by the computer